



# REFILLING AN EMPTY TANK

*On Promoting and Supporting  
Mental Wellness on Shlichus*

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## *Shlichus is a sacred privilege*

given to us by the Rebbe. It is true that the work is multifaceted and highly demanding, but when we consider the enormous privilege it entails, it becomes a joy. It is analogous to two climbers lugging heavy sacks up the mountain. The sacks are of equal weight, but one is filled with stones, the other, with gems. Naturally, the latter doesn't feel the weight. He only feels the thrill. Every step, every effort, is another measure of good fortune.

The shliach feels the same. Shlichus allows us to be fully consistent with our internal drives. One of the reasons people feel out of sorts and emotionally distressed is due to the dichotomy between their internal neshama drives and their external lifestyles. Shlichus allows us to be in complete concert with our internal selves—total symmetry between body and soul, seamless continuum from chossid to Rebbe. This perception is not our natural state. To achieve it we need to forge a daily connection with our meshaleiach. This means that we must have daily shiurim to learn the Rebbe's chassidus, we must frequently listen to the Rebbe's sichos and watch the Rebbe's farbrengens, we must regularly write duchos (reports) to the Rebbe of our progress, and, of course, come to the Ohel as often as we can.

When we lag in these practices, our connection with the meshaleiach becomes tenuous and we begin to perceive the demands of shlichus as burdensome. For this reason, the Rebbe begged, urged, and indeed commanded us to have a mashpia, who checks in with us and with whom we check in. A mashpia is a life saver. A mashpia asks pointed questions and guides us back to the proper path so that we can remain

plugged in and plug ourselves back in when we our connection has loosened.

But what if, despite our best efforts—our sincere davening, genuine self-introspection, and honest discussion with our mashpia—shlichus continues to feel stressful and we are not coping well? What if we have a mashpia, learn Chassidus, connect with the meshaleiach, and still feel anxious or depressed? If this scenario describes you, then this article is written to you.

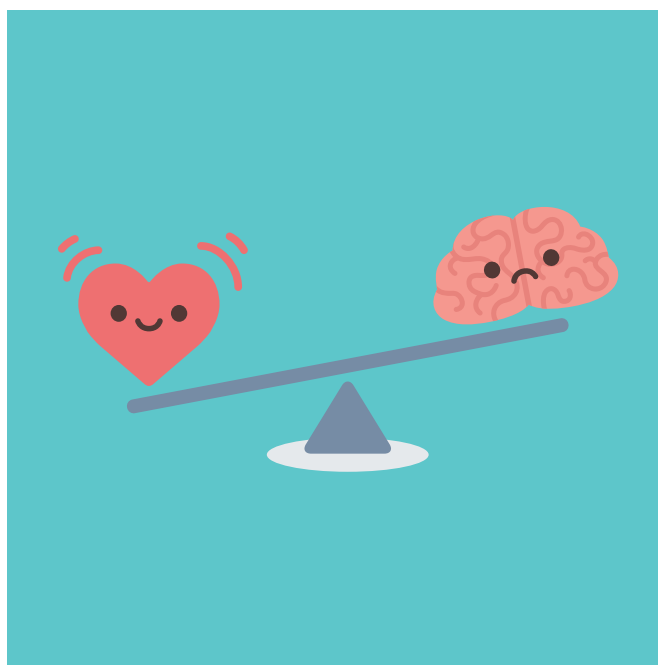
We are often a one-person show: We raise the money, we set up the chairs, and we give the sermons. We serve as chaplains, as rabbi to the community, as teacher to children and adults, and as directors, administrators, and fundraisers to our Chabad Houses.

Shluchos also wear many hats: rebbetzin to the community, counselor and confidante to scores of women, administrator and often teacher at the pre-school, Hebrew school, Mommy-and-Me programs, and junior congregations. We host dozens of guests on Shabbos and yom tov, not to mention the bochurim and girls who come to help out, who also need to be housed and fed.

This is just the tip of the iceberg. Throw in the many programs and classes that we run, and the full-time job of raising a family of children—often under unique and challenging circumstances. Some of us carry the additional responsibilities that come along with raising a child with special needs or tending to a family member who is unwell. At times we are also balancing our way across a tightrope of financial challenges or other crises.

If we have a teaching shlichus, our lives are just as hectic. In addition to being in the classroom all day long, we come home to provide for the family, prepare for the next day, communicate with the parents, and fulfill all the other shlichus roles that are expected of us in the context of our communities. The same is true of every other shlichus description. Shlichus, by definition, entails wearing many demanding and often conflicting hats, which can trigger tension and anxiety.

Factor in that we have few gaps in our schedule—our weekends are busier than our weekdays and the summer is often the busiest time of year. We have few mechanisms to reboot—our parents and family-support-networks are miles away from us. When we don't get a break—a chance to breathe and



relax—the feeling of never-ending can be overwhelming.

We think that people expect a superwoman and undaunted rabbi who are never flustered. We believe there is no room for error or for a bad day as we field phone calls, drop-ins and constant interruptions. We think that everyone expects to be treated with patience and good cheer. We feel that everyone deserves our empathy, so we bottle the stress and soldier on.

Our task, as laid out by the Rebbe, is to reach every Jew in our *mokom hashlichus*. This threshold for success inspires in

us a relentless drive to push harder and harder. We push ourselves to the brink, thinking that if we take a moment for ourselves, we are violating the Rebbe's mandate.

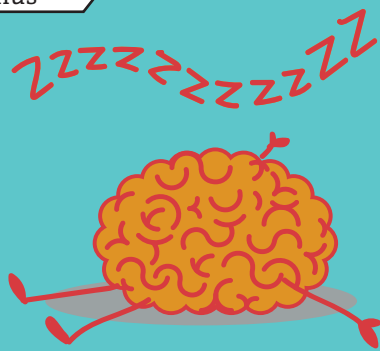
But what happens when it becomes too much? The doorbell rings during our children's bedtime and we don't feel like putting on our smile to welcome an ill-timed guest. The phone rings and we just don't have the gumption to put on a cheery voice and greet our caller. The sun rises and we just don't have the energy to get out of bed.

We give ourselves a break and skip

a scheduled program, we don't invite guests one Shabbos, we go to sleep early and don't prepare for Hebrew school. In our eyes, this is a failure. We feel like we have let down our shlichus and our meshaleach. But we couldn't help it. We just ran out of gas. Tomorrow, we tell ourselves, we will be back on track.

Sometimes taking a break works well and by the next day, we are back to normal. If that's the case, wonderful. We go back to work.

But sometimes, tomorrow comes and it isn't better. We get to the office and can't get ourselves to pick up the phone.



We can't pull ourselves together to plan the next class or event. Mommy and Me has been canceled for two weeks straight, Hebrew school has been limping along, and we haven't had a guest for Shabbos in months. For a little while, funds are not raised, programs are not arranged, minyanim are not recruited, and calls are

not returned. For teachers, we arrive at school and can't face the class. We can't pull ourselves together to plan the next curriculum, grade the papers, or prepare creative activities. We tell ourselves that we are having a bad week, but a week turns into a month.

Can it be that our relentless pushing

has emptied our tank?

We reason that it is perfectly normal for people with high stress lives to end up with empty tanks. So we take a vacation for a few days. We rent a cabin and go away with the family. We fly to New York for a day or two and spend time at the Ohel. When we return, we may very well feel refreshed and ready to go.

If this has worked, great. We bounce back and get to work. But what if we go to vacation, return with high hopes, and the heaviness returns. What do we do?

We can still muddle along. Shiurim are ongoing, Shabbos minyan still happens, but some bills haven't been paid, and it is getting harder to make those fundraising calls. We are still giving sermons, cooking Shabbos meals, showing up to Mommy and Me or to our teaching jobs, but we know we are winging it, letting things slide, dropping things here and there. This pressure often strains our relationships with family and others.

It might be time to recognize the impossible. Yes. The invincible shliach or shlucha might be suffering from something deeper than exhaustion. It can happen to the healthiest of people in high-stress positions.

What to do about it? Where do we turn? What is our next step?

## MAKE THE CONNECTION

At this point we need some guidance and support. We need to reassess our lifestyle and we cannot do it alone. We need to think about a mashpia, a friend, a fellow shliach or shlucha—someone we can trust. It can be someone we heard talking about this subject at a kinus. It can be someone we listened to at a farbrengen. It can be someone we have long admired from afar or a friend we have known all our lives.

The key is to find a person who won't chastise and will listen. Truly and fully listen with empathy and without judgement. There are many shluchim and shluchos who help fellow shluchim in precisely this situation with a listening ear and an understanding heart. Just being heard is helpful. It is not only about

It is best to assemble a support network from a cross-section of backgrounds. Our network might consist of three to five people: a family member, a fellow shliach, a mashpia, a good friend, or any other support personnel we feel could be helpful. Having multiple people to call on ensures that there is always someone with a unique angle for the particular problem we want to address. As well, it prevents us from wearing out our supporters. We should, however, remember that the Rebbe instructed us to have only one mashpia. The other people in our network should provide support rather than guidance. They should help us carry out our mashpia's guidance rather than offer alternative guidance.

What will our mashpia discuss with us?

surprising that our physical tank is empty, too. So, the first thing is to ascertain that we take time each day to study Torah and especially the Rebbe's Chassidus. Learning Chassidus daily plugs us into our purpose and our source; it injects a *chayus* into our *avodas hashlichus*. As is true of any commitment, it will be more successful if we pair up with someone and do it together. (To be paired with a fellow shliach as a chavrusa on the subject and scheduling of your choice, email [info@](mailto:info@)

jnet.org.)

When we have covered all of the above and still feel like our tank is empty, our mashpia will examine our daily schedule

## YOU ARE IMPORTANT

Sometimes we feel guilty for diverting time and resources from our shlichus to focus on ourselves. We are soldiers on the front lines and dare not take time off for personal reasons. We feel that we shouldn't allocate precious time and resources from our shlichus for personal use. Each moment is precious and every dollar is scarce. If we might reach an additional Jew with these resources, how dare we misappropriate it for ourselves?

These thoughts crawl into our minds and wrap themselves in the bunting of chassidishkeit. We recall our mashpi'im

Rabbi Levi Jacobson, shliach to Thornhill, Ontario, who counsels many shlichim in such situations, suggests that it is important to recognize these guilty thoughts for what they are: inaccurate twistings of a true concept.

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that we are unimportant, but this is not its true meaning. Bitul means that we are larger than ourselves. Our interests, ta'avos and passions are not the sum total of our existence. We are part of something larger. We are part of shlichus, part of the Rebbe, part of Atzmus Umehus. If we are part of something important, then our individual part is important too. If something is not working, we need to take time to worry about us. Providing for our own health—mental and physical—is part of our shlichus.

If a shliach broke a leg, chas veshalom, he would not think twice about taking time for physiotherapy. Mental and emotional health is just as critical to the fulfillment of our shlichus, says Rabbi Jacobson. Taking time off to chat with our mashpia and support network is critical to our shlichus.

Rabbi Jacobson suggests that we take a cue from the Rebbe, who always took time to smile at people and make them feel good about themselves. When a child came by for dollars, the Rebbe would pay special attention, often playing with the dollar bill until the baby took it. If a little boy came by with an army cap, the Rebbe would stop and salute to make the child feel good, to let him know that he is important, that he deserves the Rebbe's attention. It did not matter how busy the Rebbe was at any given moment; if a

child was nearby, the Rebbe stopped to hand him or her a coin for tzedakah.

If we are important, if we are part of something important, if we deserve the Rebbe's time and attention, then we deserve our own attention, too.

If this means allocating funds to hire a time manager to help us manage our time, we shouldn't feel guilty. This is

take a break and hold all calls for thirty minutes each afternoon, we should take it. Whatever it takes to ease the burden and empower us to fulfill our shlichus is important for us to do. We are part of a critical task force and our health is critical to its success.

An ounce of prevention is better than a pound of cure. Mrs. Rivka

Caroline, shlucha to Key Biscayne Florida, who has a Master's degree in psychology and counsels many shlichos on matters of emotional health, advocates that we build stress relievers into our schedule *before* we develop a problem. We often think that we have to keep doing until we drop. The truth is that more gets done when we work ten hours than when we push on for eighteen hours, so it is important that we build in those down-times. Even if we didn't start out that way, we can start doing it now. If we invest in our mental health now, it will pay dividends down the line, when our families and mosdos are even larger and demand even more of our energy.

Of course, we are not the best judge of what and when we need for ourselves. This is why the Rebbe insisted that we each find a rav, a personal mashpia.

Having a mashpia who understands our needs, desires, and spiritual condition is a life saver. If we feel it is time for a vacation, we should consult with our mashpia. If we feel the need to allocate Chabad dollars to help us set up systems to manage our time or to hire help at home, we should let our mashpia make the call. He or she knows

### אומן לא מרעי אומנתו

במ"ש אודות רופא מומחה א"י שיש לו שם טוב גם בני בני ישראל, ושואל חוות דעתי - לא הבנתי מה הספק בזה, כי בעיני רפואה אין מבדילים בזה, ואומן לא מרעי אומנתו, וכמו שראינו במעשה בפועל אפילו מנשיאינו הק', ובפרט שכותב שהוא דתי.

(אג"ק חי"א, מכתב ג'תק"ב)

### CONSULTING WITH A NON-JEWISH PROFESSIONAL

With respect to your question about a professional, but non-Jewish doctor, who has a good reputation in the Jewish community, and you ask my opinion on the matter: I don't understand the reason for doubt in the matter for when it comes to healing we don't distinguish on the basis of faith. What's more, an expert does not undermine his expertise. And we have seen actual examples of this from our holy Rebbeim. This is especially true since you write that the doctor is religious.

our shlichus. If we need time to vacation with our family, especially after Tishrei, Pesach or camp, we are not betraying our shlichus. This is part of shlichus. If we need time to do something that we enjoy, a (halachically acceptable) hobby or sport—daily or weekly—to get our minds off the stress and to rejuvenate, there is no need to feel bad. If we need to

our needs, concerns, and shlichus. When our mashpia advises it, we know it is the Rebbe's *rotzon*, too.

All these efforts must be in concert with, not in place of, our spiritual efforts at rejuvenation. We must continue to learn Chassidus daily, farbreng with fellow chassidim, write to the Rebbe and go to the Ohel. Both tracks are important. Just because we have discovered that we need physical relief doesn't detract or absolve us from our need for spiritual rejuvenation.

## MENTAL ILLNESS

What happens if we have found the best mashpia, leaned on an excellent support network, and our situation has still not improved? How do we know when it is time to seek professional help?

Rabbi Dr. Joseph Shagalow, shliach to S. Louis Park, Minnesota and licensed

psychologist, suggests that if we have spoken to our mashpia two or three times over the course of a month and the advice has not helped us, if we feel that the stress is mounting, if it interferes with our daily function and we are not coping, it might be more than burnout. If we can't get up in the morning, if we are burdened by shame and pressure, we might be dealing with an illness that requires medical intervention.

Sometimes it is difficult to gauge for ourselves, which is why it is critical to check in with others. If our spouse feels that we have not been improving, it is wise to trust his or her judgement and seek out a professional. In this vein, Dr. Shagalow advises that we be on the alert for signs of mental health issues in our spouses (see sidebar for a list of symptoms).

Shluchos often enjoy confiding in sisters and friends. If we notice that our sibling or friend's routine has changed, if they have fallen out of touch with us, we

should pick up the phone and reach out. We should not discuss it with her sisters or spouse but speak to her directly and find out if anything is going on in her life. We might be the person who helps her notice her problem. We should let her know that we care and that she won't be judged. She can talk about it and we can help her seek assistance.

## SEEKING MEDICAL ASSISTANCE

It is critical to destigmatize mental illness. Dr. Shagalow explains that depression is really a physical illness—a chemical depletion caused by extensive stress that drains our psychic energy. We describe it as mental only because we feel it in our attitude. But it really means that we

# SYMPTOMS of ANXIETY & DEPRESSION

The following is a partial list of symptoms associated with anxiety and depression. If you experience some of these symptoms or notice them in your spouse, it is wise to consult with your doctor:

- Frequent and radical mood swings—from cheers to tears
- Erratic shifts from energy bursts to sluggishness
- Failure to meet appointments or run routine errands and constantly making excuses
- Loss of interest in formerly enjoyable projects or hobbies
- Social withdrawal and even isolation
- Unexplained fatigue and lack of energy
- Loss of patience
- Frequent loss of temper
- Inability to control eating or other habits
- Lack of focus and inability to concentrate
- Frequent crying
- Excessive dwelling on negative events of the day
- Excessive dwelling on death or tragedy, especially following a loss of someone close
- Feelings of inadequacy
- Excessive bouts of indecision
- Sudden secretiveness

lack physical energy—no different than having the flu.

In the old days, mental illness was seen as a mark of shame to be concealed. Today we recognize that the brain, like every human organ, has a stress-bearing limit, which, when overloaded, can malfunction. This is not shameful. This is the reality of the life that Hashem created for us. Mental illness is not old fashioned laziness that can be solved by learning extra Chassidus, a little kabalas ol and a good farbrengen. This is a physical illness that requires medical treatment.

If it requires treatment, we need to seek a competent doctor. Just as it is a mitzvah for a diabetic to take insulin, so is it a mitzvah for a person to take medication to help him or her cope. *Ain chovush matir es atzmo*, a prisoner

cannot free himself. We are imprisoned within our mental challenges. We don't have the key and must turn to a specialist with the correct key.

It is critical to seek out a doctor. But where should we begin to look?

Mrs. Caroline suggests that we don't need to begin with a psychiatrist. Our first resource should be the family doctor, who can prescribe a medication. Dr. Shagalow suggests that shluchos might consider visiting their OB/GYN, who tend to be familiar with the medical treatment of mental health issues. However before consenting to any prescription, we should make sure to gather information. We need to ask our doctor to explain the prescription—its benefits, side effects, and alternatives. It is important to find out if the medication is addictive and then to make an informed decision.

Sometimes, the initial medication is not enough and we need to see a psychiatrist. Sometimes we need to see a psychologist or therapist. Mrs. Shaina Rosenfeld, shlucha to Hamilton, Ontario and a strong advocate for mental wellness, suggests that our personal physician can serve as a window to mental health professionals in our locale and help us explore our options.

Is it important that we seek a Lubavitch or frum professional?

Dr. Shagalow points out that all medical professionals today are trained to respect the religious sensitivities of their patients. With respect to whether one should seek out a frum or non-frum professional, Dr. Shagalow says that there are benefits and drawbacks to each. The frum—and especially the Lubavitch—doctor will be more familiar with our needs; the non-Jewish doctor might be more objective and respectful. The key is to choose a doctor who has experience and with whom we feel comfortable. (See sidebar for an answer from the Rebbe on this subject.)

If we choose to work with a local professional who is not frum, Dr. Shagalow suggests that we ask our family physician, especially if he is a rofeh yedid, to chat with the mental health professional. This will help bridge the cultural gap between the professional and us. Our doctors know us well and can convey our needs to the professional in clinical terms. Mrs. Caroline adds that our mashpia should also serve as a resource for our mental health professional. Creating an open dialog between our mashpia and doctor can be an ideal way for our mashpia to guide the doctor on healing us through the lens of Chassidus.

Mrs. Rosenfeld points out that a key benefit to choosing a local doctor is the face-to-face connection that we will make. Nevertheless, if we want to be treated by a frum mental health professional, it is possible to be treated from afar via phone or Skype. This is especially practical for shluchim in third-world countries. Mrs. Caroline suggests that if we are being treated long distance, we should make the trip to visit our mental health professional in person at least once.

Similar to the search for a proper mashpia, our mental health professional also needs to be the right shidduch for us. Sometimes a competent and effective doctor is just not the right match. So, if the first doctor that we find is not right for us, we should try another.

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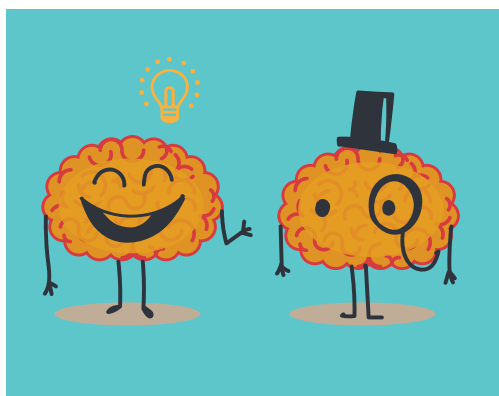
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How do we determine whether our doctor is right for us?

Mrs. Caroline suggests that if, after seeing the mental health professional two or three times over the course of a month, we don't feel like we have connected and don't get the sense that we are laying a foundation for improvement, it might be time to seek a new mental health professional. However, before switching mental health professionals, we should take the time to self-examine. Is the mental health professional not right for us, or are we reluctant to discuss personal and uncomfortable subjects? If it is the latter, changing mental health professionals might not help.

We might want to seek objective advice from our spouse, mashpia, sibling, parent, or support network to determine whether switching mental health professionals is the right decision for us.

Consulting fellow shluchim and shluchos who struggle with similar issues can be a critical piece of our support network. However, in this regard, Rabbi Jacobson cautions against switching therapists merely because a colleague advised us against a particular treatment plan. Well-meaning fellow patients, who lack training and knowledge, are often

biased to the treatment plan that works for them. They get tunnel vision and reject every other form of treatment. Each situation is unique and what works for one does not necessarily work for others. Thus, the best-intentioned advice can lead us down the wrong path.

### GOING PUBLIC?

How much should we share with our communities?

Dr. Shagalow explains that there are two stages. In the beginning, when a shliach or shlucha is in full-blown crisis, it is inappropriate to dump his or her problems on the community. Announcing that he or she is anxiety-ridden or depressed and have been dysfunctional for weeks is a violation of the social contract and of their boundaries.

Rabbi Jacobson points out that though it is not wise to share many details at this point, it is acceptable for shluchim to solicit medical references from individual members of their community. It is not shameful to seek professional assistance to overcome a problem. People respect that the shliach or shlucha is open-minded enough to seek professional help.

Mrs. Caroline points out that it might also be necessary to confide in key members of the community to explain our sudden absence and to seek their support in the community.

Once the crisis has past and we are in maintenance mode and moving forward, Dr. Shagalow believes it can be beneficial to share, but only if we can turn it into a positive experience—if we can make it inspirational.

Mrs. Rosenfeld reports that many shluchim find sharing with their community to be a positive experience. Seeing that shluchim are not ashamed of their frailties has helped the community feel closer to them. Vulnerability is credibility. When people see that we are normal and have human frailties, they relate better to us. Mrs. Caroline cautions that different people have different needs. An extrovert might feel the burden of keeping it quiet while an introvert might feel that going public is a burden. We also need to consider the needs of our spouses, whose comfort level might be different from ours.

The key is to know that we are not under obligation to hide or to share. There is nothing shameful about our condition; we have done nothing wrong.

## “לפעמים תכופות ביד הרופא להועיל במדה חשובה”

ובנדון דיד' יש להתיעץ עם רופא פסיכולוג כיון שכמה פעמים ואפשר גם ברובם, הנהגה כאותה שהוא מתאר במכתבו תלוי במתיחת עצבים וכיו"ב, ולפעמים תכופות ביד הרופא להועיל בזה במדה חשובה... ויהי רצון שבקרוב יוכל לבשר טוב בהאמור, ומוכן ופשוט שכלל שיוסיף הוא הכותב אודות הנ"ל ובני המשפחה בכלל בעניני תורה ומצות, יתוסף בברכת הש"ת בכלל ובמילוי בקשתם בהנ"ל בפרט.

(אג"ק חט"ו ע' רכד)

### *“A Psychologist Can Often Provide Substantial Relief”*

In your case, you should consult with a psychologist, as the behaviour [of your son] as you describe in your letter is often—and perhaps usually—the result of stress and the like, and very often the psychologist can provide substantial relief....

It is a chemical imbalance and we are dealing with it. On the other hand, we are still normal if we choose to keep it private.

If we choose not to share with our community, we must create a private support network and reach out. The isolating impression that we are alone with our mental challenges can be devastating. Whether we confide in family, friends, or community, it is critical to confide and not keep the situation under wraps.

Dr. Shagalow explains that, by its nature, mental illness causes one to isolate; the desire to withdraw is the illness. The chemical that provides satisfaction from human contact is depleted. We can infuse it artificially, but we don't want to become dependent on medication. Instead, we want to reach out because socializing replenishes this chemical. The more we connect, the more it builds us up. It stimulates the brain and helps us heal. Most doctors will use antidepressants to jumpstart our ability to connect, but, once we engage, it is best to wean off the medication and use our social network.

Mrs. Rosenfeld cautions us to choose

our confidants with care. Choose people who are safe and empathetic. Some parents are excellent sources of support, others might grow hysterical and overly concerned. Some friends might be empathetic, others might seem apathetic. We should share our challenges only with those who are helpful.

### SUPPORT FOR SPOUSE

It is also critical that the supporting spouse receive support. When the spousal relationship becomes one-sided and we are constantly giving without receiving, we need to find support elsewhere.

Mrs. Rosenfeld suggests that the supporting spouse schedule an appointment with a mental health professional and develop an understanding of what to expect. In addition, the supporting spouse could be in contact with one or two people in the shlichus community who themselves are supporting spouses. Siblings can also be a wonderful resource, especially for shluchos. If the suffering spouse agrees,

the supporting spouse could turn to one or two siblings for emotional support.

Beyond emotional support, the supporting spouse will require physical support—additional help at home and at the Chabad House. We might want to reach out to key members of our community, tap the resources within our families, and hire whatever additional help we need. It will cost a lot of money, but it will preserve our sanity as we provide support.

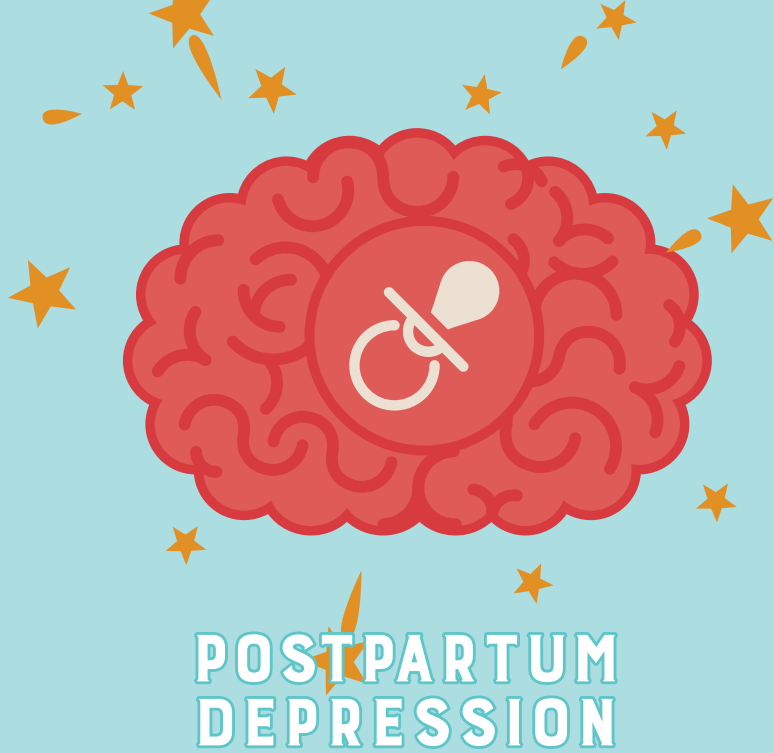
### G-D GIVEN CHALLENGE

Mental illness is an overwhelming challenge and difficult to cope with. But let's remember that it is a challenge created for us by the Aibershter through which we can grow and become better human beings, better chassidim, and better shluchim. We cannot overcome this challenge by ourselves, which is why the Aibershter gave us mental health professionals and medications. By availing ourselves of these G-d given tools, we can grow from the challenge rather than be buried by it. Each challenge directs us to new opportunities. These opportunities form our unique purpose in life and the particular flavor of our shlichus.

Buried deep within us are the strengths we need to face our challenges and grow from them. When we tap into these strengths we discover the particular plan that the Aibershter has charted for us through the framework of illness and healing. This is not a shameful episode to bury, it is the springboard to the unique role that we will play as a spouse, parent, and shliach.

There is light at the end of the tunnel. Depression and anxiety are treatable. Once we begin to heal, we become a different person. The cloud will lift, we will feel lighter, and people will pick up on it. We will be happier around people and they will be happier around us. We will feel as if heavy stones have been lifted from our chest and giant boulders have been removed from our path.

May we merit to overcome our challenges and to heal from them. ☺



Postpartum depression (PPD) is particularly devastating because it comes at a vulnerable time and is usually severe.

It is important to know that extreme stress and depression after childbirth is common. Unlike the “baby blues” typically experienced within the first six weeks following childbirth, PPD is unpredictable. It can strike perfectly healthy mothers. It can last for days, weeks, months, or longer. It can strike after one childbirth, leave the mother unaffected after the next baby, and then strike again after the third baby is born.

This is a vulnerable time for the family. The mother is still recovering from labor and delivery. The infant has instant needs. The older children have insistent needs, and the mother, who has suddenly developed critical emotional needs, is unavailable to her children. Mothers can feel particularly guilty over their inability to be available for their baby.

Mothers with PPD need daily reminders that they have not done anything wrong. This is a chemical

imbalance. Their chemical balance has been depleted by an excruciating experience. Husbands must be emotionally and verbally and consistently supportive to help their wives overcome feelings of shame and guilt. Sometimes, keeping PPD a secret can enhance the shame and guilt. Consider letting the word out because it is likely that people will support rather than judge. If it feels normal to them, it can help you feel normal about it too.

PPD is not a passing condition that will right itself on its own. Neither does it pass in a few short days. PPD is an authentic illness that requires professional help. The good news is that there are wonderful ways to treat PPD. In addition, it is critical to bring more assistance into the home. It is a bonus when family members can come to help, but they will not be able to shoulder the entire burden by themselves. Hire additional help and accept well-meaning offers for assistance from community members and friends.



## *What's the Story With Alcohol?*

One of the reasons alcohol is so addictive is that it is actually a depressant. This is not immediately apparent because the immediate effect of alcohol consumption is a lifting of spirit. But after the high comes a depressing low—a low that is chemically produced by the alcohol.

Herein lies the one-two punch of alcohol. We feel low and need a lift. We turn to alcohol, which gives us that lift, but then it hits us with a protracted low. The result is an even stronger need for relief and, naturally, we turn back to alcohol. A vicious spiral is formed that traps us in its vortex.

Having a l'chaim by a farbrengen or simcha is not an addiction. When we have a l'chaim before a stressful meeting or before giving a difficult presentation, we know we have crossed the line into addiction. A simple rule is this: If we need a l'chaim in order to function or to relax, even it is only in stressful and rare situations, we might very have crossed the line into addiction. Try the following test: make your next stressful phone call or enter your next stressful meeting without a Ll'chaim and see how you perform.

Overcoming addiction is beyond the scope of this article, but understanding this dynamic can help us avoid it in the first place.

## RESOURCE DIRECTORY\*

*Many shluchim, shluchos, and Anash, some of whom have been listed below, have extensive knowledge and experience in this field. They can guide us on how to take our next step and refer us to excellent resources and mental health professionals.\**

- **Anonymous Shluchim Helpline**  
Confidential call-in number:  
818-495-5292  
Confidential email address:  
help@shluchimlifeline.com

### ADOLESCENTS, TEENAGERS

- Rabbi Zalmen Leib Markowitz, Monsey, New York: 914-906-6878, rabbimarkowitz@merkomentors.com
- Rabbi Yarden Blumstein, West Bloomfield, Michigan (addiction, suicide prevention) 248-895-4850, yarden@friendshipcircle.org

### CHILDREN

- Children with Special Needs and their Families: Yaldei Shluchei HaRebbe, Rabbi Sholly Weiser, 646-558-5854, yaldei.com

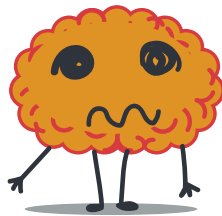
### DEPRESSION AND ANXIETY

- Mrs. Shaina Rosenfeld, Hamilton, Ontario: 905-546-7458, shaina@chabadhamilton.com

### GENERAL

- Rabbi Baruch Epstein, Chicago, Illinois: 773-510-6770
- Rabbi Levi Jacobson, Thornhill, Ontario: levijacobson@gmail.com
- Mrs. Rivka Caroline, Key Biscayne, Florida: 305-785-9535

*\* This directory has been compiled based on the suggestions of a number of shluchim and shluchos. Merkos L'Inyonei Chinuch and Compass Magazine do not endorse nor accept liability for the referrals, resources, or services provided by the names listed above, nor for any outcomes thereof.*



## דיווח אישי של החלמה שלימה

במענה למכתבו שהגיע באיחור זמן, בו כותב אודות המצב במשפחה\* ביחוד בענייני בריאות [מחלת עצבים] וכו' ושואל דעתי בזה.

והנה בכלל תמונה מה שכותב שכאילו אמר רופא שאין סיכויים להחלמה שלימה, בה בשעה שכמה מקרים ידועים ברור שנתרפאו בהחלט. ומביניהם גם כאלו שאני רואים, וזה יותר מכעשר שנה שהם בסדר ולא עוד אלא שבתנים נשאו (כי המדובר זה שמכירו הנני משך כל הזמן, ה' רווק ונשא והוליד בנים) ומשתכר בפרנסה קבועה.

בהנוגע למאורע מיוחד אי אפשר לדעת ברור ובהחלט אבל פשוט, שאמירת רופא בסגנון האמור, תמונה ביותר, ולכל היותר ובכלל בן אדם יכול לאמר, שאינו ערב ואינו לוקח אחריות בהנוגע לעתיד, ותו לא מיד.

\* המצב: מחלת עצבים.

(אג"ק ח"כ ע' כפג)

In response to your letter in which you write about the situation in the family, particularly with regard to [mental] health etc., and you request my opinion:

In general, that which you write that supposedly the doctor said there is no hope for complete recovery is surprising. There are numerous cases where it is clearly known that [the affected individuals] were totally cured. Among these are individuals I have seen personally, and they are doing fine for over ten years now. What's more, in the interim they have married and are holding permanent jobs. (The individual I am referring to, whom I have known the entire time, was single [at the time of the illness] and has since married and had children.)

It is impossible to know with certainty [what will occur] in a particular case, but it is obvious that for a doctor to express himself in such a way is extremely surprising. At most, he (or a person in general) can say that he cannot guarantee and accept responsibility for the future, but nothing more.

(Igros Kodesh, Vol. 20, p. 183)



## Inner Anxiety

Often, anxiety takes root because a person's external character is incompatible with his or her inner self.

The anxiety may dwell upon other issues and obsessions—but none of these are the true underlying cause.

Most souls can tolerate a few inconsistencies. But others are sensitive to every nuance.

As soon as some aspect of their lifestyle is not attuned to the purity of the essential self, the entire person is thrown off balance.

That is why, for a Jew, being more careful about the mitzvot will often diminish anxiety.

**From a letter to a woman suffering anxiety**